

PHIL 402 – Introduction to Phenomenology

Part I – Husserl's Founding of Phenomenology

Week 1 – Introduction: What is Phenomenology?

1. Preliminaries

Notes:

Welcome! I am excited about this class and I hope to infect you all with some of that excitement. To start we need to run through some basics:

What you can expect from me:

- I will be available. If you email me, I will respond. If you come to office hours, I will help you.
- I take the work very seriously. I will come prepared to work for every class.
- I will listen very carefully to any questions or concerns you may have about the content of the course or otherwise.
- I will try to find a balance between hard work and fun. After all, it is the summer.

What I will expect from you:

- That if you are on your computer that you will stay off social media.
- That you will take the work seriously and work hard yourself.
- That you will do your best to participate meaningfully in the class in a way that is both comfortable and uncomfortable (i.e. I want you all to push your cognitive boundaries a bit).

Some notes on pedagogy and the institution:

Academic relationships are complicated and structured by institutional power-dynamics that can stymie the necessary trust that is involved in going deep with philosophical ideas. I will actively try to cut through those kinds of dynamics.

However, I am a very intense person. This is often a positive thing for my students, but for others it is not. Thus, you should try to decide quickly whether my particular way of doing things is pedagogically and psychologically suitable to you. If not, you may want to enroll in another course.

Important: I want this class room to be a **safe space** in the sense that we respect people. That should go without saying. We must be kind and fair. But I also want it to be an **unsafe space** just in that we take risks and push ourselves to transcend our previous conditions of knowing and learn new things.

Syllabus run through: I have included a lot on this syllabus. I will go through it with you now. Please consult it before asking me procedural questions.

How to read:

- i. The texts are very hard. Probably some of the hardest philosophy you've ever encountered. Thus, it's important that you make space in your schedule for reading. This course will cover a lot of material so your attention will be required in order to get through the material for class and then write about it for your papers.
- ii. For every week you should see how many pages you are required to read and then divide that by the number of days you have. If you do this, you should average about 15 pages of reading per day. This is a reasonable amount to read for a 400-level course and if you stick to the daily reading schedule, you will find it easy to stay on track.

2. Husserl and the Founding of Phenomenology

Edmund Husserl (1859-1938): The Founder of Phenomenology

- Born in the Czech Republic. Jewish, but converted to Catholicism when he was 27.
- Got his PhD in Mathematics and then studied philosophy with Franz Brentano in Vienna.
- Corresponded with Cantor and Frege about the epistemic foundations of mathematics and the problems of psychologism (more below).
- Mentor to Martin Heidegger, who we will study in this class.
- When the non-Aryan laws came to pass in Germany in 1933 under Hitler and the Nazis, Husserl was directly affected and was suspended from the University.
- He died just before the start of WWII.
- The *Husserliana* is the collection of Husserl's works, many of which have never been published. He was so prolific that he often wrote several versions of entire books.

Overview of Phenomenology as a Philosophical Enterprise

- Husserl began his philosophical study under Franz Brentano and his works were deeply inspired by the latter's research on the nature of intentionality.
 - *Definition:* Intentionality is that in virtue of which mental states can be said to be *about* something.
 - For Brentano, intentionality was 'the mark of the mental'. That is, what it is for something to be mental — in Brentano's words, 'psychical' rather than 'physical' — is for it to possess the attribute of intentionality.

- Phenomenology is the study of consciousness from the perspective in which it is lived. That is, first-personally. It is the study of the *structure* of consciousness, of those features of experience that are invariant. In this way, Phenomenology is the philosophical pursuit of *essences*.
 - An *essence* is that in virtue of which a phenomenon is what it is. It is the whatness-maker of a thing.
 - Insofar as we are able to *know* essences by being conscious of certain kinds of truths (as embodied by logic and math), Husserl thinks this entails that there are ideal forms that we are acquainted with intellectually in thought.

Historical Antecedents:

- Plato: Forms as the means to true knowledge.
- Descartes: An emphasis on the conscious subject as the road to grounding knowledge.
- Kant: Transcendental philosophy (more on this in two weeks). Husserl uses the strategy of careful *description* as a form (transcendental) argument.

3. Against Psychologism

Consider the following bit of logic:

$$\begin{array}{c} p \rightarrow q \\ p \\ \hline q \end{array}$$

Now consider this bit of mathematical reasoning: $7 + 5 = 12$

Some Questions:

- What makes it the case that these inferences are good ones?
- In virtue of what are we able to *know* that this is so?

Possible answers:

- i. *Platonism*: Numbers are metaphysical entities in a 3rd-realm we intellectually intuit with our rational minds.

Problem: metaphysically suspect.

- ii. *Empiricism*: numbers are abstract entities derived from general patterns in our sensory experience.

Problem: Doesn't work. Numbers exist in concepts, not in objects.

- iii. *Logicism*: Numbers are derived from the fundamental principles of logic (Frege and Russell almost blew up their brains trying to make this work).

Problem: Arguably assumes what it seeks to prove.

And worst of all....

- iv. *Psychologism*: A view that claims that the laws of logic and mathematical inference are grounded in the mental processes of human subjects. This means that the truths of logic and math are contingent facts of the way we happen to think rather than something more, like universal, objective, mind-independent laws.

Problem: Gives up utterly on the objective purport of math and logic, relegating it to the psychological functions of the human mind.

Husserl's Response: Phenomenological Philosophy

4. Husserl's Encyclopedia Britannica Article "What is Phenomenology?"

This article provides a rather rigorous summary of Husserl's evolving conception of Phenomenology as a method of doing philosophy. This article gives a nice overview of key points that we will treat of this week in only a cursory fashion. If you didn't understand it, fret not, this article represents several stages of Husserl's thinking and we will unpack the main contours of Husserl's evolving conception of Phenomenology over the next several weeks.

To begin, here is a brief statement of Husserl's twofold definition of Phenomenology: "The term "phenomenology" designates two things: a new kind of descriptive method which made a breakthrough in philosophy at the turn of the century, and an *a priori* science derived from it; a science which is intended to supply the basic instrument (*Organon*) for a rigorously scientific philosophy and, in its consequent application, to make possible a methodical reform of all the sciences" (Husserl, 77).

- Descriptive method: a way of describing our experience *structurally*, as it unfolds in real time, from the 1st-person perspective.

- An *a priori* science: Husserl thinks that once experience is fully grasped structurally, that the possibility of any experience can be systematically elucidated, thus articulating a *systematic* foundation for the possibility of any experience, including the experience of knowledge of particular sciences.

4.1 The Discovery of Intentionality

Husserl begins his analysis with a description of the foundations of psychology, which is the one special science that deals directly, if empirically, with the nature of the mind.

“Modern psychology is the science dealing with the “psychical” in concrete relationship to spatio-temporal realities. In other words, it deals with the relationship of what occurs in nature as egoical, with all that inseparably belongs to it as psychic processes like experiencing, thinking, feeling, willing, as capacity, and as *habitus*. Experience presents the psychical as merely a stratum of human and animal being. Accordingly, psychology is seen as a branch of the more concrete science of anthropology, or rather zoology” (Husserl, 77-8).

- Another relevant science here that Husserl does not mention: neuroscience. The idea, is that from an *empirical*, or factive, point of view, psychology is a branch of the specialized sciences that can be grounded in other ‘more concrete’ sciences that focus on behavior (anthropology) and physiology (zoology and neuroscience).
- Explanations in these sciences incline towards that which is concrete in the sense of *actual* and observable from the third-person perspective. Husserl will try to say that an understanding of our psychology can also lead to an awareness of what the structure of the conscious mind is like from the first-person perspective.

The most core structural feature of ‘psychic processes’ that Husserl is concerned with is *intentionality*, the mind’s directedness towards things: “This relatedness of the appearing to the object of appearance resides in the meaning of all expressions in the vernacular languages which relate to psychic experience—for instance, perception *of* something, recalling *of* something, thinking *of* something, hoping *for* something, fearing something, striving *for* something, deciding on something, and so on” (Husserl, 78).

Husserl claims that this is an ‘immanent essential feature’ of all experiences: “The terminological expression, deriving from Scholasticism, for designating the basic character of being as consciousness, as consciousness of something, is *intentionality*. In unreflective holding of some object or other in consciousness, we are turned or directed towards it: our “*intentio*” goes out towards it. The phenomenological reversal of our gaze shows that this “being directed” (*Gerichtetsein*) is really an immanent essential feature of the respective experiences involved; they are “intentional” experiences” (Husserl, 78).

One of Husserl's gifts, is his ability to bring a technically descriptive acumen to basic phenomenon of our daily lives that might otherwise escape a critical, reflective gaze. This is the part of Phenomenology that we termed *descriptive*. Let's work through this example he gives us about the nature of perception. We will spend many weeks learning to reflect Phenomenologically on our basic pre-reflective perceptual experiences in this class, especially during Part III when we read large sections of Merleau-Ponty's *Phenomenology of Perception*.

A preliminary phenomenological description of a perceptual experience:

"So for example in starting from a perception of something (for example, a die), phenomenological reflection leads to a multiple and yet synthetically unified intentionality. There are continually varying differences in the modes of appearing of objects, which are caused by the changing of "orientation" -of right and left, nearness and farness, with the consequent differences in perspective involved. There are further differences in appearance between the "actually seen front" and the "unseeable" ("*unanschau/ichen*") and relatively "undetermined" reverse side, which is nevertheless "meant along with it". Observing the flux of modes of appearing and the manner of their "synthesis", one finds that every phase and portion is already in itself "consciousness-of"-but in such a manner that there is formed within the constant emerging of new phases the synthetically unified awareness that this is one and the same object" (Husserl, 79).

So within a singular perceptual experience, there are components which are synthesized to give us a sense of there being a determinate and unified intentional object. And this holds true not just of perception but of all other modes of intentional awareness as well: "If this same thing is intuited in other modes – for example, in the modes of recollection, fantasy or pictorial representation - to some extent the whole intentional content of the perception comes back, but all aspects peculiarly transformed to correspond to that mode" (Husserl, 79).

It is this descriptive analysis of the intentional structures of conscious experience that Husserl takes to be the proper task of Phenomenological psychology: "For psychology, the universal task presents itself: to investigate systematically the elementary intentionalities, and from out of these [unfold] the typical forms of intentional processes, their possible variants, their syntheses to new forms, their structural composition, and from this advance towards a descriptive knowledge of the totality of mental process. towards a comprehensive type of a life of the psyche" (Husserl, 79).

4.2 Bracketing the Natural Attitude

But for Husserl, it is not enough to just describe in precise details the contours of the intentional life of consciousness. He also believes that it is possible to bracket (*epoche*) any commitment to what he calls the 'natural attitude', our ordinary understanding of the world as 'out there' separate from the operations of our own mind and instead to see the world as a world of experience, something that

appears to consciousness precisely because of the structures and activities of that consciousness.

Passage: “A consistent *epoche* of the phenomenologist is required, if he wishes to break through to his own consciousness as pure phenomenon either in the case of individual phenomena or as the totality of his purely mental processes. This means that in the performance of phenomenological reflection he must inhibit every copformance of objective positing operative in unreflective consciousness, and [operative also, of course] in the mode of judging, where what is posited is the world as it exists for him purely and simply” (Husserl, 80).

- Husserl’s idea here is that we have a natural tendency to posit that the world we experience every day is ‘out there’ independent of us.
- He thinks that the world’s seeming to us this way – for it to appear to us as if it is just ‘out there’, independent of the mind’s operations – is itself a kind of positing of the mind, a ‘natural attitude’ that we take towards the pre-reflective deliverances of ordinary experience.
- Becoming aware of this ‘natural attitude’ and consciously bracketing our commitment to it is the work of the *epoche*.

Here’s an argument from non-veridical experience for why we should trust the *epoche* as a coherent way of engaging with the structure of experience.

“It is, after all, quite impossible to describe an intentional experience - even if illusory, an invalid judgment, or the like - without at the same time describing the element of consciousness in it *as such*. The universal *epoche* of the world as it becomes conscious (the “putting it in brackets”) shuts out from the phenomenological field the world as it simply exists; its place, however, is taken by the world as given in *consciousness* (perceived, remembered, judged, thought, valued, etc.) - the world *as such*, the “world in brackets,” or in other words, the world, or rather individual things in the world, are simply replaced by the respective meaning of each *in consciousness* (*Bewusstseinssinn*) in its various modes (perceptual meaning. Recollected meaning, and so on)” (Husserl, 80).

The argument reconstructed in standard form:

1. Veridical experience and non-veridical experiences have the same intentional content. They are about the same things.
2. If veridical experience and non-veridical experience have the same content, then there is an element of consciousness ‘as such’ that obtains across veridical and non-veridical experiences.
3. Therefore, there is an element of consciousness ‘as such’ that obtains across veridical and non-veridical experiences.

4. If there is an element of consciousness 'as such' that obtains across veridical and non-veridical experience, then we can describe its content and structure without any commitment to whether or not the experience is veridical.
5. Therefore, we can describe the content of consciousness 'as such' without any commitment to whether or not the experience is veridical.

Here's Husserl again: "In going back from the unities already given in the natural attitude to the manifold of modes of consciousness in which they appear, the unities, as inseparable from these multiplicities - but as "bracketed" are also to be reckoned among what is purely psychical, and always specifically in the appearance-character in which they present themselves. The method of phenomenological reduction (to the pure "phenomenon", the purely psychical) accordingly consists (1) in the methodical and rigorously consistent *epoche* of every objective positing in the psychic sphere, both of the individual phenomenon and of the whole psychic field in general; and (2) in the methodically practiced seizing and describing of the multiple "appearances" as appearances of their unitary objects and their unities as unities of components of meaning [or "constituted sense"] accruing to them each time in their appearances" (Husserl, 80).

So what we are being asked to do is to go from the structures evident in our ordinary experience of the world to the recognition that these structures in fact enable us to be in touch with the regular world, in the natural attitude. But that these structures can be described apart from our ordinary commitment to the world that they disclose because they are the *conditions of possibility* for that very commitment.

4.3 Transcendental Subjectivity

Husserl's understanding of Phenomenology takes a transcendental turn at the mid-point of his career. Here is a key passage from the article that we can read through together and analyze carefully:

"In it [the natural attitude] the world is for us the self-evidently existing universe of realities which are continuously before us in unquestioned givenness. So this is the general field of our practical and theoretical activities. As soon as the theoretical interest abandons this natural attitude and in a general turning around of our regard directs itself to the life of consciousness - in *which* the "world" is for us precisely that, the world which is present *to us* - we find ourselves in a new cognitive attitude [or situation]. Every sense which the world has for us (that's we how become aware of), both its general indeterminate sense and its sense determining itself in particular details, is, within the internality of our own perceiving, imagining, thinking, valuing life-process, a conscious sense, and a sense which is formed in subjective genesis. Every acceptance of something as validly existing is effected within us ourselves; and every evidence in experience

and theory that establishes it is operative in us ourselves, habitually and continuously motivating us” (Husserl, 83).

The idea, at its most basic sense, is that a positing intersubjective consciousness is the condition of possibility for the presence of any world whatsoever. Here’s Husserl: “From this starting point the full and complete being-sense of a possible world in general and in regard to all its constitutive categories, shall be elucidated. Like every meaningful question, this transcendental question presupposes a ground of unquestioned being, in which all means of solution must be contained. This ground is here the subjectivity of that kind of conscious life in which a possible world of whatever kind. is constituted as present” (Husserl, 85).

So, through an introspective encounter with our own psychology, we transition to a transcendental phenomenological philosophy whereby our description of the structures of conscious life don’t just tell us about what our minds are like *in the world in which we’re living*, but also lay bare the transcendental intersubjectivity in virtue of which any possible world would be manifest.

Husserl: “Transcendental subjectivity, which is inquired into in the transcendental problem, and which subjectivity is presupposed in it as its ground of being is none other than again “I myself” and “we ourselves”; not, however, as found in the natural attitude of every-day or of positive science; i.e., apperceived as components of the objectively present world before us, but rather as subjects of conscious life, *in which* this world and all that is present- for “us” constitutes itself through certain apperceptions” (Husserl, 85).

Remember, *doing* Phenomenology requires a shift in attitude and this is not an easy thing to accomplish because we are so often locked into the natural attitude, even when we are being theoretically reflective: “...the transcendental attitude involves an alteration of focus from one’s entire form of lifestyle, one which goes so completely beyond all previous experiencing of life, that it must, in virtue of its absolute strangeness, needs be difficult to understand” (Husserl, 87).

Husserl’s endgame is to claim that Transcendental Phenomenology is a kind of meta-science that provides methodological foundation for all regular scientific practice: “The consequence that arises [from all this] with reference to the *a priori* sciences that have come into being historically and in transcendental naivete is that only a radical, phenomenological grounding can transform them into true, methodical, fully self-justifying sciences” (Husserl, 88).

Why? Because all first-order scientific discourse assumes a grounding in the systematic manifestation of appearances to the scientific gaze.